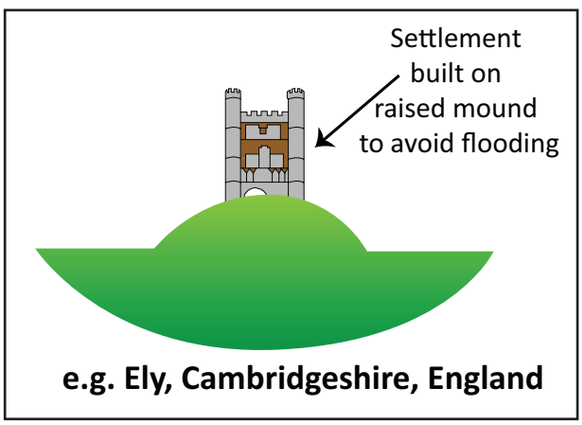
1. Water supply

Water supply is probably the single most important factor in deciding where a settlement might be located. Not only do rivers provide a source of clean drinking water, they also provide a food source through fishing, and a transport route. Most of the world's largest cities are located on rivers, especially the point at which they reach the sea, as this was often the first point that explorers landed.

2. Dry point sites

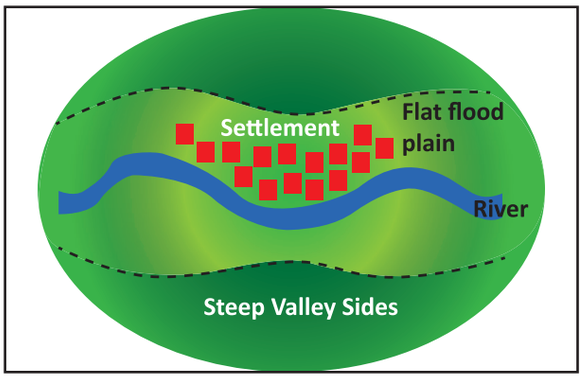
A dry point site is one that is slightly raised from the surrounding area, meaning that it is less likely to flood. Ely in Cambridgeshire, England, is a good example of dry point site.





3. Wet point sites

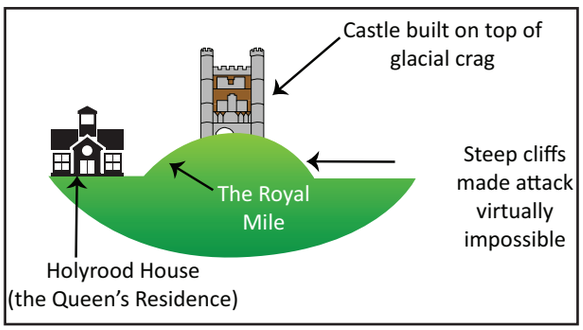
Wet point site refers to any site that has access to water, usually through being beside a river. Towns would either grow up along the river or clustered near the point at which the river enters the sea. Examples of wet point sites include the towns and villages of the Welsh valleys, which tend to extend along the flat valley floor, rather than up the steep valley sides. Spring line settlements in the North and South Downs, England are also good examples of wet point sites.



4. Defence

In medieval times, defence was one of the most important factors influencing the site of a settlement. The relief of the land often proved to be the best form of defence. Edinburgh castle sits on the top of a glacial crag, in an almost perfect position to defend itself, with very little chance for the attackers. In Italy, there are many walled hill-top villages, whilst the Maoris in New Zealand built their settlements (called Pa's) on the top of steep hills to prevent being attacked. In India, Ichhapur Defence Estate is a census town in Barrackpore, West Bengal.

The other common natural feature used for defence is water, and in particular rivers. Both Shrewsbury and Durham are very good examples of where a meander of the river has formed an area of land bounded by water on three sides. This provided both cities with excellent defence, as they only had a thin neck of land to defend.



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